

WORKSHOP REPORT

Reimagining Capacity Building for Grassroot Governance

National Learning Week | Sadhana Saptah 2026

April 7, 2026 · Krushi Bhavan, Bhubaneswar, Odisha

Organized by: Capacity Building Commission (CBC), Government of India

In collaboration with: Government of Odisha & Kaivalya Education Foundation (KEF)



National Workshop	Reimagining Capacity Building for Grassroot Governance
Date	April 7, 2026
Location	Krusha Bhavan, Bhubaneswar, Odisha
Hosted by	Government of Odisha
Organized by	Capacity Building Commission (CBC), Government of India
Supported by	Kaivalya Education Foundation (KEF)
Initiative	National Learning Week – Sadhana Saptah

1. Executive Summary

The national workshop on “Reimagining Capacity Building for Grassroot Governance” was organized on 7 April 2026 at Krushi Bhavan, Odisha, as part of the National Learning Week of the Capacity Building Commission, observed as Sadhana Saptah under the Viksit Panchayat Initiative. The workshop aimed to collectively reflect on the future of capacity building for Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs).

The workshop brought together representatives from multiple states, senior government officials, civil society organizations, State Institute of Rural Development and Panchayati Raj (SIRD&PR) leadership, and elected and appointed Gram Panchayat representatives. The multi-state participation enabled rich peer learning and cross-learning from diverse governance contexts.

The central objective was to shift the discourse from training as a one-time event to capacity building as a continuous, competency-based ecosystem — emphasizing technology, peer learning, experiential learning, and measurable governance outcomes.

The “Sadhana” Framework

The workshop was anchored in the “Sadhana” framework — Strengthening Adaptive Development and Human Aptitude for National Advancement — across three pillars:

Technology Leveraging AI & digital tools for real-time, accessible support to PRI functionaries.	Tradition Integrating civilizational knowledge, local wisdom, and contextual practices into governance.	Tangible Outcomes Ensuring capacity building translates into measurable improvements in governance & Antyodaya.
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2. Inaugural Session

The workshop commenced with the arrival of the Hon'ble Minister, Shri Ravi Narayan Naik (Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Department and Rural Development, Government of Odisha). A key highlight was a walkthrough of state exhibits under the Viksit Panchayat Initiative, showcasing field-level innovations from

SESTA (Assam), CYSD (Odisha), UNNATI (Gujarat), and Kaivalya Education Foundation teams from Andhra Pradesh and Odisha.

2.1 Highlights of Inaugural Session

- › **Karmayogi Gaan:** The workshop opened with the “Karmayogi Anthem” — a song emphasizing the transition from being a worker to a Karmayogi (selfless service-oriented professional).
- › **Plant Watering Ceremony:** A ceremony held to symbolize growth, continuous learning, and environmental consciousness.



2.2 Key Participants & Dignitaries

Name	Role & Organization
Shri Ravi Narayan Naik	Hon'ble Minister, Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Dept. and Rural Development, Govt. of Odisha
Dr. R. Balasubramaniam	Member (HR), Capacity Building Commission (CBC), Govt. of India
Shri Girish S.N.	Commissioner-cum-Secretary, Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Dept., Govt. of Odisha
Smt. Madhusmita Samal	Director, State Institute of Rural Development & Panchayati Raj (SIRD&PR)
Other Attendees	SIRD Directors, MoPR Officials, NIRDPR Representatives, CSOs, and elected GP representatives from Assam, Odisha, Gujarat & Andhra Pradesh

2.3 Inaugural Addresses



Dr. R. Balasubramaniam — Member (HR), CBC

Dr. Balasubramaniam emphasized moving the national capacity building approach beyond input-based metrics toward outcome-oriented competency development, highlighting:

- › **Moving Beyond Numbers:** From measuring the number of people trained to assessing actual enhancement in competencies and governance capabilities.

- › **De-siloization of Learning:** Joint capacity building of elected representatives (Sarpanches) and government functionaries (Secretaries) as a single functional unit.
- › **Anytime, Anywhere Learning:** Digital platforms including WhatsApp-enabled chatbots and mobile-based learning modules for continuous learning.
- › **Peer & Experiential Learning:** Strengthening learning through field-based experiences and structured peer exchange.

Ministerial Address — Shri Ravi Narayan Naik



- › **Shift from Rule to Role:** Moving from rule-based governance to role-based governance, where every official is a Change Agent rather than just a file processor.
- › **Localized Learning:** Training must be in vernacular languages (Odia, Gujarati, etc.) rooted in local case studies.
- › **The ‘Dadan’ (Migration) Challenge:** A commitment to make Odisha “Dadan Mukt” (Migration Free) using GP systems to map migrant families and provide local livelihoods through MGNREGA, PM-Kisan, and Skill Training.

- › **Vision 2036 & 2047:** Odisha to be the Front Engine (Dabba No. 1) of the Indian economy by 2036 and contribute to Viksit Bharat by 2047.

2.4 Launch of E-Learning Platforms

The Hon'ble Minister digitally launched the AI-enabled Viksit Panchayat chatbot and multilingual e-learning modules in the presence of Dr. R. Balasubramaniam and senior officials. An e-learning module on Own Source Revenue (OSR) was displayed, demonstrating how PRI representatives can understand OSR concepts and apply revenue generation techniques.

Case Study: Bali Gram Panchayat, Koraput District

- › Identification of local assets such as ponds, markets, and cashew orchards
- › Use of Gram Sabha for validation and collective ownership of decisions
- › Generation of over ₹4 lakh annual revenue through leasing and user fees
- › Revenue reinvested into drinking water systems, road infrastructure, and streetlights
- › Desilting ponds and leasing for commercial use — a direct demonstration of fiscal decentralization driving improved service delivery



3. Technical Session: Viksit Panchayat Initiative

Shri Basharat Ali, Senior Program Manager (KEF), outlined the initial findings of the pilot project that provided strong evidence for the competency development needs across PRI functionaries:



- › While community attendance in Gram Sabhas is relatively high, grievance resolution remains weak
- › Decision-making and structured problem-solving emerged as the weakest competencies in Sarpanches
- › Significant knowledge asymmetry exists between secretaries and elected representatives on Panchayati Raj Acts and fiscal provisions
- › Only a very small proportion of PRI functionaries fall in the high competency zone, indicating need for sustained mentoring support

This evidence strongly validated the need for a robust competency development ecosystem in PRI training.

4. Voices from the Field: Real-World Transformation

Four representatives from Gram Panchayats across states shared how specialized capacity building has created tangible transformation in their villages:

ODISHA**Govardhan Kandiki**, Sarpanch

Focused on Own Source Revenue (OSR). By identifying damaged community assets like cashew orchards and ponds, and leasing them transparently through Gram Sabha processes, the panchayat now generates ₹4–5 Lakhs annually for local development.

GUJARAT**Kishore Bhai**, Sarpanch

Addressed the ‘Lonely Leader’ syndrome. Previously, the Sarpanch and Talati made all decisions alone while committees existed only on paper. Now, by activating sub-committees, the decision burden is shared and decisions are genuinely community-owned.

ASSAM**Himani Daimari**, Ward Member

Highlighted the Digital Leap. As a first-time elected member, she used the AI Chatbot and iGOT modules to understand GPDP and OSR — proving that technology can bridge the knowledge gap for newcomers to governance.

ANDHRA PRADESH**V. Cheeni**, PDO

Shared a Market Innovation story. In a tribal belt where world-class coffee was sold to middlemen for ₹40/kg, the Gram Sabha used its training to pass a resolution on Value Addition. By processing coffee locally, they are targeting ₹600/kg — drastically increasing village wealth.



5. Panel Discussions

A major strength of the national workshop was the depth of three thematic panel discussions, which collectively moved the conversation from event-based training toward comprehensive systems transformation.



Panel 1: From Training to Transformation – Rethinking Capacity Building for PRIs

Moderator Mr. Manmohan Singh, CEO, Kaivalya Education Foundation

Panelists

- › Shri Jagadananda — Mentor & Co-Founder, Centre for Youth and Social Development
- › Shri Ashok Kumar H. — Senior Indian Administrative Service Officer
- › Shri Rajesh Kumar Singh — Joint Secretary, Ministry of Panchayati Raj
- › Dr. Anjan Kumar Bhanja — Associate Professor, NIRDPR
- › Dr. Sisir Kanta Pradhan — Pathway Lead, Common Ground

Key Discussion Points:

- › Moving from one-time trainings to continuous learning journeys
- › Embedding the 70-20-10 Learning Architecture into PRI strengthening
- › Strengthening Funds, Functions, and Functionaries (3Fs) for meaningful decentralization
- › Using Asli Pradhan edutainment films to address proxy leadership and women's agency
- › Integrating LSDG Themes and Panchayat Development Index (PDI) into self-assessment
- › Real transformation requires a mindset shift: from administrative compliance to village leadership



Panel 2: Leveraging Technology for Last Mile Governance

Moderator Shri Rishi Arora, Core Team Member, Piramal Foundation

Panelists

- › Shri Sumeet Singh — Director, Capacity Building Commission
- › Ms. Erica Arya — India Head, Tech4Dev
- › Shri Alok Arunam — Senior Programme Manager, CEGIS
- › Shri Dron Kumar Chandrakar — Senior Programme Manager, Foundation for Ecological Security

Key Discussion Points:

- › Technology as an ‘invisible enabler’ integrated into daily governance workflows
- › Role-based information support for Sarpanches, ward members, and secretaries
- › Voice-first interfaces to overcome literacy barriers at the grassroots
- › Panchayat scorecards and PAI dashboards for evidence-based decision-making
- › AI as a real-time learning companion in the flow of work
- › Technology must adapt to the user — human-centred and problem-solving in orientation



Panel 3: Tradition, Community, and Governance Outcomes

Moderator	Smt. Anuja Tarini Mishra, Odisha Administrative Service
Panelists	› Shri Elango Ramaswami — Social Reformer › Shri Liby Johnson — CEO, Gram Vikas › Ms. Pranati Das — Associate Director, Janagraha › Shri Pradyut Bhattacharjee — Executive Director, SeSTA

Key Discussion Points:

- › Grounding governance reforms in community contexts and local socio-cultural systems
- › Balancing traditional governance wisdom with modern equity frameworks
- › Moving from representation to meaningful agency for women elected representatives
- › Bridging top-down policy intent with bottom-up lived realities
- › Behavioral change as the foundation for sustainable governance outcomes
- › Strengthening Gram Sabhas as the bedrock of participatory democracy

6. Key Takeaways & Institutional Support

Sumeet Singh, Director of the Capacity Building Commission (CBC), summarized the day's core findings and institutional learnings:

Integration Learning must be integrated with daily governance practice, not siloed as periodic events.	Institutional Anchors NIRD&PR and SIRDs must act as primary anchors for the national capacity building ecosystem.
Tangible Outcomes The ultimate metric for success is visible improvement in governance at the grassroots level.	Future-Ready Systems Systems must be human-centered, technology-enabled, community-rooted, equity-driven, and outcome-focused.

Workshop Institutional Learnings:

- › Capacity building must shift from training delivery to competency ecosystems
- › AI + WhatsApp + iGOT offers strong potential for last-mile support across 2.5 lakh Panchayats
- › Joint learning of PRI elected representatives and secretaries is highly effective
- › Field mentoring and peer learning should complement formal modules
- › Multi-state pilots like Viksit Panchayat are generating scalable evidence for national models
- › Behavioral transformation — especially around women's leadership and committee activation — is central to governance outcomes

7. Formal Recognitions & Vote of Thanks

- › **Honors:** Dr. R. Balasubramaniam presented a memento to the Hon'ble Minister. Shri Sumeet Singh (Director, CBC) and Shri Girish S.N. honored other dignitaries with mementos.
- › **Vote of Thanks:** Smt. Madhusmita Samal (Director, SIRD&PR) thanked delegates from Assam, Andhra Pradesh, and Gujarat for traveling long distances to share valuable field insights.
- › **Conclusion:** The inaugural session concluded with a group photograph and a call to treat the learning process as a 'Festival' (Tyohaar) rather than a chore.

8. Conclusion

The workshop successfully created a national platform to rethink grassroots governance capacity building through the lenses of technology, experiential learning, behavioral change, and institutional convergence. The discussions strongly affirmed that Viksit Bharat is deeply linked to Viksit Panchayat.

Future investments must focus on continuous competency development, real-time support systems, and measurable governance transformation at the village level. The event reinforced the role of CBC as a national

anchor in shaping future-ready, inclusive, and evidence-driven capacity building ecosystems for Panchayati Raj Institutions across India.

“Development ahead should be regenerative and not just sustainable. We must go to the people, live with them, and think with them for their growth.”

— Dr. R. Balasubramaniam, Member (HR), Capacity Building Commission

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Capacity Building Commission, Government of India | National Learning Week 2026

